NHMEC

Community Herbalist Diploma

Level II – Applied Studies

MODULE 1

Orientation to Community Herbalism

Module Overview

Welcome to the Community Herbalist Diploma Program.

You have completed the foundational studies of the Kitchen Herbalist and Family Herbalist programs. During those courses you learned how to safely use herbs within your own home and for family wellness.

This diploma begins a new stage in your herbal journey.

A Community Herbalist serves others through education, stewardship, ethical herbal practices, and community wellness initiatives. Rather than focusing solely on making herbal preparations, the Community Herbalist learns how to become an educator, organizer, advocate, and servant leader.

This course is designed to help you develop the knowledge, confidence, and practical skills needed to responsibly share herbal education within your church, neighborhood, organization, or community while remaining within educational and ethical boundaries.

Community herbalism is founded upon service. It is rooted in preserving traditional herbal knowledge while making that knowledge accessible to future generations.

Throughout this diploma you will develop practical skills, complete community-based projects, formulate herbal preparations, create educational resources, and build confidence in serving others.

Module Objectives

Upon successful completion of this module, students will be able to:

• Explain the purpose of community herbalism.

• Describe the role of the Community Herbalist.

• Identify the core values of community herbal practice.

• Explain the difference between family herbalism and community herbalism.

• Understand the expectations of the Community Herbalist Diploma.

• Begin developing a personal philosophy of herbal service.

Required Reading

Read the following sections in the Community Herbalist eGuide before completing this module:

- Directions and Course Information
- Introduction: *The Spirit of Community Herbalism*
- Chapter 1:
    - Historical Foundations
    - The Modern Revival
    - Core Values

As you read, highlight passages that describe:

• Service

• Education

• Accessibility

• Sustainability

• Stewardship

• Respect

Learning Outcomes

After completing the reading, you should understand that community herbalism extends beyond preparing remedies. It includes:

• Teaching

• Preserving traditional knowledge

• Responsible harvesting

• Community outreach

• Building local wellness

• Environmental stewardship

• Sharing herbal knowledge ethically

Instructor Lecture

What Is a Community Herbalist?

A Community Herbalist is much more than someone who knows herbs.

A Community Herbalist is an educator.

A servant.

A steward.

A mentor.

A lifelong student.

While a Family Herbalist focuses primarily on caring for themselves and their immediate family, the Community Herbalist expands that knowledge to serve others through education and responsible leadership.

Community herbalists may volunteer at community gardens, teach beginner herbal classes, lead herb walks, write educational articles, organize wellness events, assist churches with wellness ministries, develop seed libraries, or create educational materials for local organizations.

The emphasis is always education, safety, and empowerment—not practicing medicine.

Why Community Herbalism Matters

Modern society has become increasingly disconnected from nature.

Many people no longer recognize common medicinal plants growing around their homes.

Community Herbalists help reconnect people with God's creation by teaching safe herbal practices, encouraging responsible stewardship, and preserving traditional botanical knowledge.

Their work helps strengthen individuals, families, and entire communities.

The Four Pillars of Community Herbalism

Education

Knowledge should be shared.

Teaching others strengthens entire communities.

Stewardship

Plants are gifts entrusted to our care.

Community Herbalists harvest responsibly, cultivate medicinal plants, and preserve native species.

Service

Community Herbalists serve without seeking personal recognition.

Their goal is helping others become more knowledgeable and self-reliant.

Ethics

Community Herbalists understand their professional boundaries.

They educate.

They encourage.

They support.

They do not diagnose disease or prescribe medical treatment.

Vocabulary

Define the following terms in your own words:

Community Herbalism

Herbal Stewardship

Accessibility

Sustainability

Wildcrafting

Empowerment

Traditional Herbal Knowledge

Ethics

Advocacy

Reflection Questions

Answer each question using complete sentences.

1. Why do you want to become a Community Herbalist?
2. What does "serving your community" mean to you?
3. How has herbalism changed your own life?
4. What gifts or talents do you believe you can contribute?
5. Which core value described in the reading resonates with you the most, and why?
6. What concerns do you have about teaching others?
7. How do you hope this diploma will help you grow?

Practical Activity

Community Observation Exercise

Visit one of the following:

• Local park

• Farmer's Market

• Community Garden

• Church property

• Walking trail

• Nature preserve

Observe your surroundings.

Record:

• Five medicinal plants you recognize.

• Plants you wish to learn more about.

• Evidence of environmental stewardship.

• Ways herbs could benefit your local community.

Take photographs if possible.

Record your observations in your Herbal Journal.

Herbal Journal Assignment

Create your Community Herbalist Journal.

Include:

Your goals

Favorite herbs

Areas you wish to specialize in

Courses completed

Volunteer interests

Plant observations

Quotes

Scriptures

Community project ideas

Continue adding to this journal throughout the diploma.

Assignment

My Philosophy of Community Herbalism

Write a 2–3 page paper answering the following:

Why is community herbalism important?

What responsibilities does a Community Herbalist have?

How should herbal knowledge be shared?

What role should ethics play?

How do you hope to serve your own community?

Use examples from the required reading to support your ideas.

Mini Quiz

Choose the best answer.

1. The primary goal of community herbalism is:
   A. Selling herbal products
   B. Educating and serving communities
   C. Diagnosing illness
   D. Replacing physicians
2. Which value is emphasized throughout the required reading?
   A. Competition
   B. Accessibility
   C. Commercial marketing
   D. Patenting herbs
3. Stewardship refers to:
   A. Selling herbs
   B. Caring for plants responsibly
   C. Advertising herbal products
   D. Making capsules
4. Community herbalists primarily:
   A. Diagnose diseases
   B. Perform surgery
   C. Educate others
   D. Prescribe medications
5. Sustainability means:
   A. Harvesting everything available
   B. Protecting resources for future generations
   C. Buying imported herbs only
   D. Growing only exotic plants

Module Project

Create a one-page document titled:

"My Vision as a Community Herbalist."

Include:

• Your mission statement

• Three community goals

• Three educational goals

• Three stewardship goals

Decorate it with botanical illustrations or photographs.

Module Completion Checklist

☐ Completed required reading

☐ Vocabulary completed

☐ Reflection questions answered

☐ Community observation completed

☐ Herbal Journal started

☐ Philosophy paper submitted

☐ Quiz completed (80% or higher)

☐ Vision Statement completed

Looking Ahead

In Module Two, you will explore the many roles of the Community Herbalist, including educator, facilitator, herbal formulator, gardener, steward, organizer, and advocate. You will begin applying your knowledge through interviews, outreach planning, and leadership activities that prepare you for serving your own community.